events, to win medals and accolades. A strategic plan needs to be put in place and implemented decisively and purposefully. One way could be to identify areas where talent exists and tap it—for example, wrestling in Haryana, archery in the Northeast, hockey in Punjab. Planning must be focused and enforced honestly—it is only then that India can emerge as a front liner in the sports world. Each one of us must contribute if we want to change the system.

The all-pervading influence of politics on sports has to end. A while ago, the sports ministry had invited me to sit on the board of the Athletic Federation; I attended some meetings, but soon realized that I was in the minority, and that my frank views were not welcome. Several people with vested interests resented my presence on the board, only because they felt that a veteran athlete like myself would eclipse their prominence. Often I used to wonder how people who have never played a game could have been given such important positions. Why couldn't sportspeople head sports organizations? But this can never happen, simply because vested interests will prevent such a move. More important is the fact that these are elected positions and no sportsman will be able to garner more votes than a wily and powerful politician.

When Margaret Alva was the sports minister, I often told her that all heads of influential sports bodies should have tenures of just five years, so that there will be a change in the style of functioning. I voiced the same opinion to the next minister, Ajay Maken, but only an act of Parliament can initiate such a policy.

What we can't comprehend is that the world is changing rapidly and that we will be left far, far behind if we don't move with the times. In all these decades, sports technology, too, has changed. When I was starting my career in the early 1950s, there were no running shoes, and it was only in 1956 after Roshan Sports in Patiala began to manufacture them, that they were accessible to the public. Another revolutionary change has been the introduction of synthetic tracks. This has meant that athletes have achieved feats that were considered near impossible during our times. With shoes, tracksuits and other sophisticated equipment and benefits so readily and openly available, why then is it so difficult for our sportspeople to reach international standards?

What saddens me most today is the universal use of drugs. When I used to run, the only drugs I knew of were those taken for medicinal